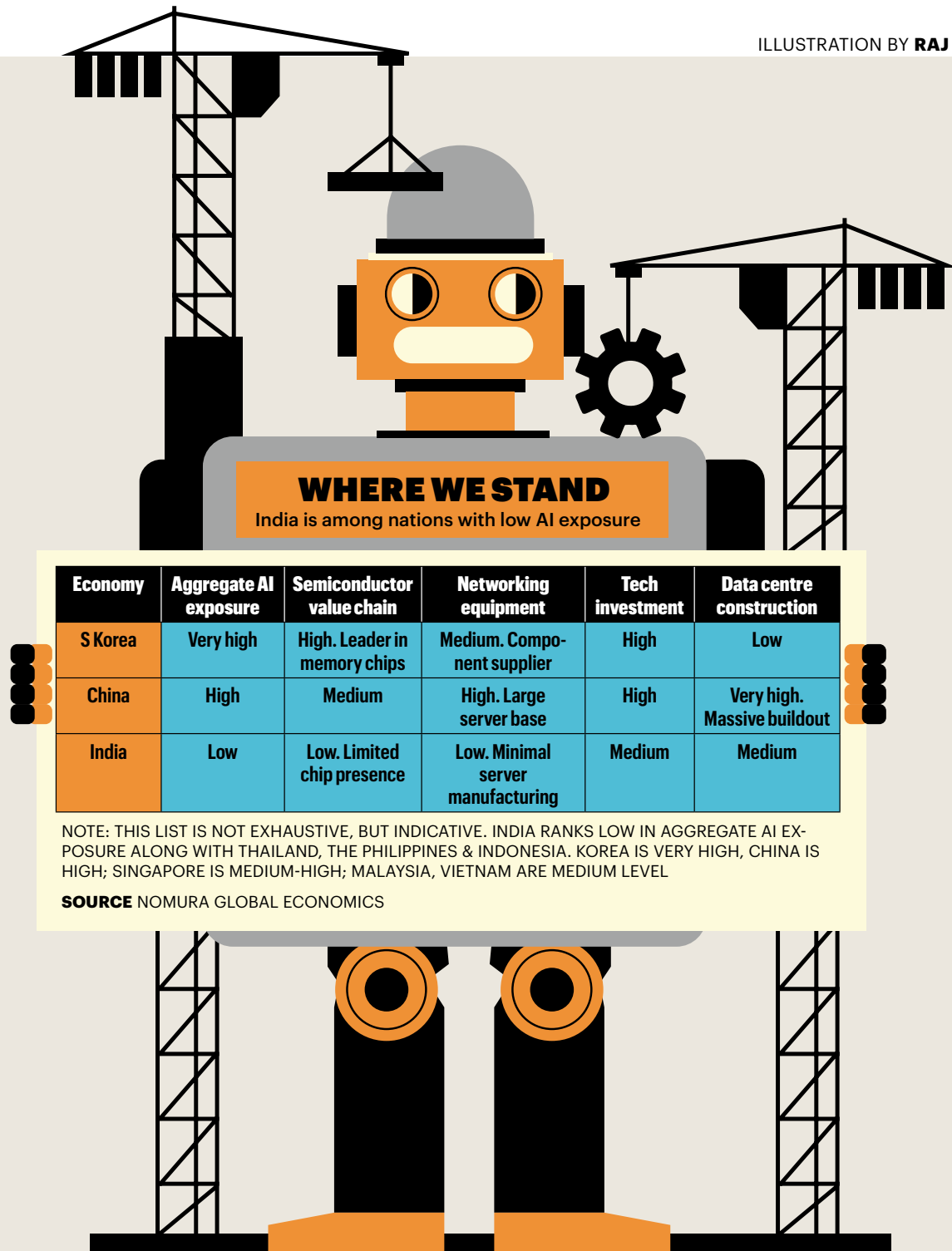




understand what it is doing, whether it meets business intent, how it behaves in production, and manage risk,” says Gupta.

The future is human-plus-AI. But this shift will disrupt India’s traditional mass-hiring model, especially when combined with the post-pandemic correction in over-hiring and a challenging macro environment.

Ramamoorthy says India can be to AI skills what it was to digital skills in the long run. But for that the com-

panies must invest in AI capabilities. “If listed IT majors protect margins too aggressively and underinvest in reinvention, it won’t help. Most are giving dividends to keep shareholders happy but not aggressively scouting for buyouts that could help them build AI capabilities.” He says nimble mid-sized firms and new-age players could capture the AI value pool. Some may have to “shrink to grow,” that is, accept near-term margin sacrifice to fund a new AI-led portfolio.